this time at the hands of imperial Japan. The Rape of Nanjing in 1937, with its deeply disturbing saga of large-scale and utterly ruthless slaughter of innocent men, women and children, the rape and inhumane violation of thousands of women and the wanton destruction of property by the Japanese imperial army, has left deep lacerations on the Chinese psyche and terrifying memories among the Chinese people. It also provoked a strong desire for thoroughgoing reform.

Initially, such reform did not involve a questioning of China's traditional culture and its inherent superiority as an advanced civilization. Zeng Guofan, Li Hongzhang and Zuo Zongtang were the key proponents of this school; they sought to strengthen Qing power by introducing Western technology and military capabilities but rejected the notion that the West had anything more to offer in terms of civilizational values and attributes. More importantly, no political reform was necessary.

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China's encounter with the West and with its more immediate neighbours, Russia and Japan, was traumatic and lies embedded in the prism through which China looks at the world around it. Chinese suspicion and mistrust of the outside world is not a contrived narrative. It is the true recounting of the brutal humbling of a proud and ancient civilization by forces it could neither comprehend nor control. China does use this narrative of humiliation as an instrument in nation-building and in elevating the CCP into the role of a national saviour. Recall what Mao said on 1 October 1949 about the people of China having 'stood up'. Some Western scholars indulging in whataboutery seek its equivalence with the violence and savagery which successive Chinese empires may have visited upon those whom they sought to subjugate. This does not detract from the very real suffering and humiliation visited upon the people of China by Western, Japanese and Russian imperialism.

China's encounter with the West led to different and sometimes complex and contrary responses. In the immediate aftermath of the Opium Wars, the Qing palace bureaucracy and the literati sought to diagnose the causes for